

FIREHALL BREAKFAST · SAUCE ONLY

THE OFFICIAL FIREHALL RED LEAD RECIPE

Tomato sauce for a proper station breakfast.



Ask ten firefighters how to make Red Lead and you will probably get ten different answers. Every hall seems to have its own version, but the idea is always the same: a slow-cooked tomato sauce served with a proper station breakfast.

Red Lead is the sauce — not the whole meal. You simmer it in cast iron, set the pan in the middle of the table, and let the crew help themselves while bacon, eggs, and the rest of the spread goes around.

This card is the sauce recipe only. Cook your eggs, bacon, sausage, toast, and potatoes separately.

Prep

10 min

Simmer

35 min

Pan

12-inch cast iron



WHY FIREFIGHTERS STILL MAKE IT

Most weeks in the hall move fast. Calls, training, paperwork, gear checks — there is not much time to sit still. Sunday breakfast is different. Somebody puts coffee on, the kitchen gets warm, and the crew actually sits down.

That is when rookies hear the old stories — bad calls, funny calls, the shift before theirs. Retired guys still talk about who ran the best sauce pan. Spouses and kids show up at halls that do family mornings. It is one of the few meals where everyone is at the table at once.

The food is simple. The point is the table.

This recipe makes only the Red Lead sauce. This recipe makes only the Red Lead sauce. Serve it with eggs, bacon, breakfast sausage, toast, home fries or hash browns, orange juice, and coffee. Nothing fancy — just the way most halls still do it.



INGREDIENTS

Tomato Red Lead sauce — scale for your crew. Cook eggs, bacon, sausage, toast, and potatoes separately.

SERVES 4

- **1 can (28 oz)** crushed tomatoes
- **1/2 cup** tomato juice
- **1/2 large** yellow onion (diced)
- **2 tbsp** butter
- **1 tsp** kosher salt
- **1/2 tsp** black pepper

SERVES 8

- **2 cans (28 oz each)** crushed tomatoes
- **1 cup** tomato juice (or thin with liquid from a can if the tomatoes are thick)
- **1 large** yellow onion (diced small)
- **4 tbsp** butter
- **2 tsp** kosher salt
- **1 tsp** black pepper (freshly ground)

SERVES 12

- **3 cans (28 oz each)** crushed tomatoes
- **1 1/2 cups** tomato juice
- **2 large** yellow onion (diced)
- **6 tbsp** butter
- **1 tbsp** kosher salt
- **1 1/2 tsp** black pepper



STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

Read it once before you start. Get the rest of breakfast moving before the onion hits the pan.

1 GET THE REST OF BREAKFAST STARTED FIRST

Red Lead needs a quiet simmer, not a pan left alone while you are scrambling to cook everything else. Put coffee on, get bacon in the oven, sausage on a sheet pan, and your toast ready before you dice the onion.

Timing: 5 min setup

Watch out: Starting the sauce first and letting it stick while the rest of the breakfast falls behind.

2 MELT THE BUTTER AND COOK THE ONION

Set a 12-inch cast iron over medium heat. Melt the butter until it foams — not brown. Add the onion and stir every minute or so until it is soft, translucent, and just starting to colour at the edges. Some crews toss in diced green pepper here; that is up to your hall.

Timing: 8–10 min

Look for: Onion bends on the spoon with no raw white left in the middle.

Watch out: Turning the heat up to rush it. Burnt butter makes the whole pan taste off.

3 ADD GARLIC, THEN THE TOMATOES

If you are using garlic, stir it in for about 45 seconds until you can smell it — do not let it brown. Pour in the crushed tomatoes, tomato juice, salt, and pepper. Stir until the colour is even and the pan looks like thick soup.

Timing: 2 min

Look for: Deep red all the way through; no pale tomato streaks.

4 SIMMER UNTIL IT THICKENS

Drop the heat to medium-low. Leave the pan uncovered and stir every few minutes so the bottom does not scorch. It is ready when the sauce coats a spoon and a swipe through the middle leaves a trail that slowly closes back up. A longer simmer is better if you have the time.

Timing: 25–35 min

Look for: Thick enough to sit on toast without running off; the raw tomato smell is gone.

Watch out: Putting a lid on too early — the steam keeps it thin.

5 TASTE IT AND ADJUST

Taste for salt and pepper. Add the pinch of sugar only if the tomatoes are sharp. A little hot sauce goes in now if your hall likes heat. Hold the pan on the lowest steady flame, or keep it in a warm oven (170°F / 75°C) with foil on top until the crew is seated.

Timing: 2 min

Look for: Savory and balanced — not flat, not sweet like candy.

6 BRING THE PAN TO THE TABLE

Carry the cast iron out when the rest of the spread is ready — bacon, sausage, eggs, toast, potatoes, juice, and coffee on the go. Set the sauce in the middle. The crew serves themselves with a spoon. That is the meal.

Timing: Serve right away

Watch out: Trying to plate this like a restaurant dish. It is hall food — shared from the pan.



FIREHALL TIPS

GIVE IT TIME

The sauce is better after a long simmer. If you can start it early and let it sit on low, do it. Leftovers reheated the next day are often better than the first serving.

SCALE FOR THE CREW

Use the 4 / 8 / 12 portions on the ingredients page. If you need two pans, split the batch evenly. Do not pile a double recipe into one skillet — the middle stays cold while the edges burn.

ROOKIE MISTAKES

Boiling hard splits the tomatoes and makes them grainy. Under-salting until the table fixes it for you. And remember — this card is the tomato sauce. Eggs and bacon cook separately.

MAKE IT YOUR HALL'S WAY

Some crews add green pepper with the onion. Some add a dash of hot sauce at the end. Garlic is optional. Do not overthink it — taste and adjust.

HOLD IT WITHOUT RUINING IT

Keep it above 140°F (60°C) on low heat or in a 170°F (75°C) oven. Stir before you carry it out. If a skin forms on top, stir it back in — do not scrape burnt pan bottom into the sauce.

SERVE IT LIKE THE HALL DOES

Put the cast iron in the centre of the table. Everything else stays on its own platters. Pass the sauce with a spoon and let people take what they want.



EGGS

Scrambled in a hotel pan or fried to order — cooked on their own, not in the sauce.

BREAKFAST SAUSAGE

Links in the oven or bulk crumbled on the griddle.

HOME FRIES OR HASH BROWNS

Griddle or oven — keep them off the Red Lead pan.

BACON

Sheet pan at 400°F (205°C) until crisp. Refill the platter.

TOAST

Thick bread, butter on the table.

ORANGE JUICE

Pitcher within reach. Top it up without being asked.

COFFEE

First pot on early. Keep it going.

Every hall has its own recipe. The important part is not who is right. It is getting the crew around the table.

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